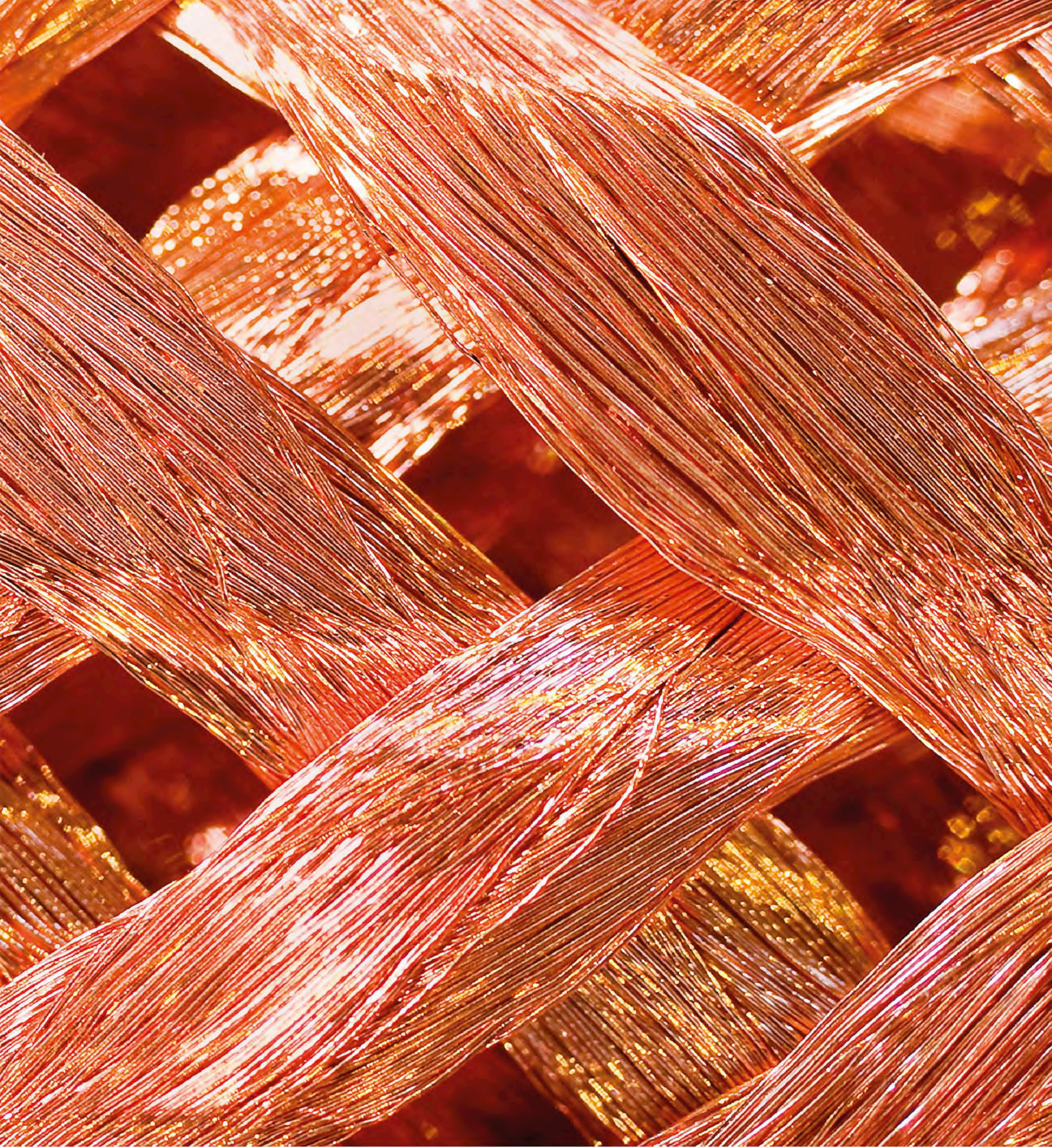




Copper is a very good conductor of electricity, but not the best; silver is better. However, copper is more widely used because it is much cheaper to find and purify. Each year, about 15 million tonnes of pure copper is produced, and more than half of it is used to make electrical components, such as this mesh. Today, more than a billion kilometres of

copper wiring is running unseen in power supplies, buildings, and electronics. Copper is now the most common electrical metal, but it has a long history. It was the first element to be refined from ores in large amounts about 7,000 years ago in the region that is now Iraq. Today, Bingham Canyon in Utah, USA, is the world's largest copper mine.